My God, the shower was going.

"What are you doing taking a shower, Gertrude?"

It seemed she wanted to be sweet and clean for the medical people.

"Who cares? It's their job. You think everyone comes in powdered and scented?"

But she wouldn't listen. We didn't get to the hospital till 3:00 a.m. Gertrude, who had settled down the instant she was in the car, decided the baby wasn't on the way and she grew discontented over my panic having forced her to the hospital. "Why do you have this tendency to panic, Isaac?" she asked.

I was feeling rather stupid, but at least it meant I could drive slowly and avoid accidents. When I pulled up at the curb at Massachusetts Memorial Hospital, a block from the Medical School, I hopped out of the car and ran around to the other door to help her out. I found her momentarily unable to move—the cramps had started again and they were lulus. Thank goodness we were there.

I checked her in and then came the wait. A first pregnancy often

involves a long labor, and by dinnertime, fifteen hours after I had taken her to the hospital, she was still in the labor room.

I kept walking up and down, leaving for the Medical School, coming back, walking up and down. Theoretically, I should only have been there in the visiting hours, but I wore my white lab coat and everyone in a hospital is conditioned to question no one in a white lab coat.

Finally, at 7:45 p.m. on August 20, 1951, right in the middle of visiting hours, of course, Dr. Elia came striding out into the hall with his face mask dangling about his neck, a huge smile on his face, his right hand thrust out.

"Congratulations, Isaac, it's a boy," he said, and the visitors standing about broke into a spontaneous cheer.

David Asimov had appeared in the world.

He was a little baby, even though he was full term. He was only five pounds, four onces, and since forceps had had to be used, his head was misshapen.

Everyone told me not to worry—that this was a common state of affairs and